Key Features of Academic English

1. **Formal Tone**
    a. Avoids contractions (e.g., *do not* instead of *don't*).
    b. Avoids slang or colloquialisms (e.g., use *children* not *kids*).
2. **Objective Stance**
    a. Focuses on facts and evidence rather than personal opinions.
    b. Uses third-person perspective more often than first-person.
3. **Hedging (Cautious Language)**
    a. Softens claims to avoid overgeneralization.
    b. Examples: *It appears that*, *may suggest*, *possibly*, *likely*.
4. **Evidence-Based**
    a. Claims are supported by research, data, or citations.
    b. Example: *According to Smith (2020), social media impacts attention spans.*
5. **Complex Sentence Structures**
    a. Uses subordinating clauses, passive voice, and nominalization.
    b. Example: *The implementation of new policies was considered effective.*
6. **Precise and Technical Vocabulary**
    a. Uses subject-specific terminology.
    b. Avoids vague terms like *things* or *stuff*.
7. **Clear Structure and Cohesion**
    a. Includes an introduction, body, and conclusion.
    b. Uses logical connectors: *however, therefore, in contrast, for instance*.
8. **Impersonal Language**
    a. Avoids overly emotional or subjective language.
    b. Example: *This essay examines...* instead of *I think...*
9. **Consistency in Style**
    a. Adheres to formatting and citation styles (APA, MLA, Chicago, etc.).

Feature	Description	Examples
1. Formal tone	Avoids slang, idioms, and contractions.	"do not", X "don't"
2. Objective/Impersonal	Focuses on facts, not personal opinions. Uses passive voice.	"The results were analyzed."
3. Precise vocabulary	Uses specific and technical terms.	"significant increase", X "a big jump"
4. Evidence-based	Supports claims with data or references.	"According to Smith (2021)..."
5. Structured and cohesive	Organized in logical sections, uses connectors.	"Moreover, however, in contrast"
6. Hedging	Uses cautious language to avoid absolute claims.	"may indicate", "appears to be"

Objective and Impersonal Language in Academic English

Definition:

Academic writing avoids personal involvement and presents ideas in a neutral and unbiased way. This helps maintain credibility and clarity.

Technique	Explanation	Example
Avoiding personal pronouns	Do not use "I", "we", "you" unless required by the task.	*I think this shows... → This indicates that...*
Using passive voice	Shifts focus from the person to the action.	*We conducted a survey... → A survey was conducted...*
Referring to evidence	Citing data or research instead of opinion.	*Studies suggest that...*
Avoiding emotional language	Stay neutral; don't express feelings or exaggerate.	*It's shocking that... → It is notable that...*
Using third-person perspective	Keeps writing formal and impersonal.	*The researcher observed...*

Examples of Formal Tone in Academic English

Informal	**Formal (Academic)**
Kids these days don't read enough.	Young people today tend to engage less in reading activities.
I think this is a big problem.	This appears to be a significant issue.
A lot of people believe that…	Many scholars or researchers argue that…
This study shows that...	The findings of this study indicate that...
We did an experiment to test this idea.	An experiment was conducted to examine this hypothesis.
The results were kind of surprising.	The results were somewhat unexpected.
It's really important to think about this.	It is essential to consider this issue.
Things got better after that.	Conditions improved subsequently.
They found out that students were tired.	It was discovered that students experienced fatigue.
This paper talks about climate change.	This paper discusses the impacts of climate change.

Tips for Using Formal Tone in Academic English:

- Use complete sentences.
- Choose precise and academic vocabulary
- Avoid contractions (*don't*, *isn't*, *we're*, etc.)
- Avoid personal pronouns (*I*, *you*) unless permitted by the discipline
- Avoid informal words (*stuff*, *things*, *a lot*, *cool*, etc.)

Informal / Personal	**Objective / Impersonal**
I believe that climate change is a big issue.	Climate change is considered a significant global issue.
We found out that students were tired.	It was observed that students experienced fatigue.
I think the results are really surprising.	The results appear to be unexpected.
You can see how this affects the economy.	This demonstrates the impact on the economy.

Informal / Personal	Objective / Impersonal
Our experiment proved the theory.	The experiment provided evidence supporting the theory.

What Is Precise Vocabulary in Academic English?

Precise vocabulary means choosing the **most specific and accurate words** to describe ideas, actions, or data. This improves clarity and avoids vague or general language.

Vague / General	Precise / Academic
a lot of people	a significant number of individuals
get better	improve / recover / strengthen (choose as needed)
stuff / things	materials / variables / factors / items
really big	substantial / considerable / extensive
kind of / sort of	somewhat / partially / moderately
say	argue / claim / state / assert / suggest
bad	detrimental / harmful / ineffective
good	beneficial / advantageous / effective
help	assist / support / facilitate
make	produce / generate / construct / develop

Less Precise	More Precise
A lot of kids don’t like school.	A significant proportion of students express dissatisfaction with school.
The results show a big difference.	The results indicate a statistically significant difference.
This stuff affects how people learn.	These cognitive factors influence learning outcomes.
Some people think it's bad for health.	Several researchers argue that it may pose health risks.

Non-Evidence-Based	Evidence-Based
I think social media is harmful to teens.	Research by Johnson (2022) suggests social media use increases anxiety among adolescents.
Many students don't like online classes.	According to a survey by Lima (2021), 68% of students prefer in-person classes.
Climate change is getting worse.	NASA (2023) reports that global temperatures have increased by 1.1°C since 1880.
Bilingualism is good for the brain.	Studies have shown that bilingual individuals often display greater cognitive flexibility (Bialystok, 2015).

Cohesion (Flow of Ideas)

Cohesion is about **linking ideas smoothly** across sentences and paragraphs.

Function	Examples
Addition	furthermore, moreover, in addition, also
Contrast	however, on the other hand, although, in contrast
Cause/Effect	therefore, as a result, consequently, thus
Examples	for instance, for example, such as
Clarification	in other words, that is to say
Sequencing	first, second, next, finally

What Is Hedging in Academic English?

Hedging means using cautious or tentative language when making claims. It reflects that knowledge is often **uncertain, complex, or subject to change**—especially in academic contexts.

Rather than stating something as an absolute fact, academic writers **soften** their claims to sound more balanced, objective, and credible.

Verbs	Modal Verbs	Adverbs	Phrases
suggest	may	possibly	It is possible that...
indicate	might	likely / unlikely	It appears that...

Verbs	Modal Verbs	Adverbs	Phrases
tend to	could	generally / typically	The evidence seems to suggest...
seem	can	somewhat / relatively	There is some evidence to show...

Without Hedging (Too Strong)	With Hedging (Better Academic Style)
This study proves that stress causes heart disease.	This study suggests that stress may contribute to heart disease.
Online learning is better than face-to-face classes.	Online learning appears to be more effective in certain contexts.
All teenagers suffer from sleep deprivation.	Many teenagers are likely to experience sleep deprivation.
Climate change is caused by humans.	Climate change is likely influenced by human activity.

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